PARSHAT LECH LECHA · SHIUR READER

ראֹשׁ יְשִׁיבָה וְשַׂר צָבָא

ROSH YESHIVA AND ARMY GENERAL

A world war breaks out in Eretz Yisrael. It is not Avraham's war. Then he hears that Lot has been taken captive, and the Rosh Yeshiva closes the Gemara, locks the doors, and leads his students into battle.

RAV EITAN BENDAVID · KEHILLAT SHIVTEI YISRAEL, RA'ANANA · 6 MIN VIDEO · WATCH THE SHIUR →

NOT HIS WAR

In Bereishit 14, four kings led by Amrafel go to war against the five kings of Sedom. On the surface this has nothing to do with Avraham. He didn't start it, and these aren't his people. But then he hears that Lot has been captured, and the Torah calls Lot *achiv*, "his brother." Lot is his nephew, but Avraham feels him as a brother.

BEREISHIT 14:14

וַיִּשְׁמַע אַבְרָם כִּי נִשְׁבָּה אָחִיו וַיָּרֶק אֶת־חֲנִיכָיו יְלִידֵי בֵיתוֹ שְׁמֹנָה עָשָׂר וּשְׁלֹשׁ מֵאוֹת וַיִּרְדֹּף עַד־דָּן׃

When Avram heard that his kinsman had been taken captive, he mustered his retainers, born into his household, three hundred and eighteen of them, and went in pursuit as far as Dan.

WHY TELL US THIS STORY?

The Radak and the Abarbanel both ask why the Torah records this war at all. The **Radak**: it shows how righteous Avraham was and how much faith he had in Hashem, and it teaches that a person must put his own life at risk to save his family. The **Abarbanel** takes it further: the story shows the *completeness* of Avraham's character, in three qualities:

- **Gevurah** — courage, toughness, the willingness to fight.
- **Ahavat krovim** — love for family, even for Lot, who left Avraham for Sedom and arguably didn't deserve rescue.
- **Nedivut and gadlut halev** — generosity and largeness of heart.

HIS YESHIVA GOES TO WAR

Who are Avraham's comrades in battle? The pasuk calls them *chanichav yelidei beito*. The Radak explains that they were the people Avraham had taught to serve Hashem, the souls "he made in Charan." In the Rav's words: *these are essentially his yeshiva bachurim.*

RADAK ON BEREISHIT 14:14

חֲנִיכָיו... הַנְּעָרִים שֶׁלִּמְּדָם בְּדֶרֶךְ הָאֱמֶת לַעֲבֹד אֶת ה׳

His trainees: the young men whom he had taught the way of truth, to serve Hashem.

> *"What does Avraham do when it's time for war? He closes the Gemara. He closes the yeshiva. He locks the doors, and he takes all of his yeshiva bachurim, led by the Rosh Yeshiva, out to war."*
>
> —RAV EITAN BENDAVID

NOT A THREAD, NOT A SANDAL STRAP

After the victory the king of Sedom offers Avraham the spoils. Avraham refuses all of it. He did what he did because it was right, and he will not let Sedom say it made him rich.

BEREISHIT 14:22–23

וַיֹּאמֶר אַבְרָם אֶל־מֶלֶךְ סְדֹם הֲרִמֹתִי יָדִי אֶל־יְהוָה אֵל עֶלְיוֹן קֹנֵה שָׁמַיִם וָאָרֶץ: אִם־מִחוּט וְעַד שְׂרוֹךְ־נַעַל וְאִם־אֶקַּח מִכָּל־אֲשֶׁר־לָךְ וְלֹא תֹאמַר אֲנִי הֶעֱשַׁרְתִּי אֶת־אַבְרָם:

I swear to Hashem, God Most High, Creator of heaven and earth: I will not take so much as a thread or a sandal strap of what is yours; you shall not say, "It is I who made Avram rich."

RAV LICHTENSTEIN, RAV AMITAL, AND COMMON SENSE

Rav Aharon Lichtenstein zt"l wrote "The Ideology of Hesder," a long article that marshals Rambam, the sources on milchemet mitzvah, and more to show why talmidim must also fight. His colleague at Yeshivat Har Etzion, Rav Yehuda Amital zt"l, said he didn't understand why the article was needed: *how could a country function without an army?* The Rav's point is that both matter: the halachic sources, and the *sechel hayashar*, the basic logic of the human heart, which says that when your people are in danger, you go and do something.

> *"We should be able to go back to yeshiva. Avraham should be able to open up the books again. But that's not the reality we're living in. Until then, we follow Avraham's model."*
>
> —RAV EITAN BENDAVID

FOR THE SHABBAT TABLE

1. The Torah calls Lot Avraham's "brother." Who counts as your "brother" when they're in danger?
2. Why might it matter that Lot didn't really deserve to be rescued?
3. Why does Avraham refuse even a thread from the king of Sedom? What would have been lost if he had taken it?
4. Rav Amital trusted common sense; Rav Lichtenstein built the halachic case. When do we need each?